

VANGUARD

ASCENT OF THE WEFT

EPISODE

06

A THRILLING
NEW CHAPTER
IN THE CRUSADE
FOR THE SKY.



INSIDE THE BASTION

RENN. SLOANE. ONE ARTIFACT. THREE WAY STANDOFF.

THE WEAVER'S THIMBLE



THE AURELIAN HEIGHTS
CAPITAL OF THE CELESTIALS.
EIGHTY THOUSAND FEET
ABOVE THE EARTH.

WHERE WEALTH ASCENDS,
AND THE PUREST RULE
UNTIL THE WORLD
FADES BELOW.

NONE ARE WELCOME.
ALL ARE USEFUL.

THE WHITE CROWN

BOOK I: ECHOES ABOVE

WE COME
NOT AS FOOLS,

BUT AS CARGO.

ゴオオオ...

IDENTIFY YOUR
SHIP AND DECLARE
YOUR CARGO.

MERCHANT
CONVOY.
DRY GOODS,
TOOLS, GRAIN.
NOTHING MORE.

HMM.
ANOTHER
GRAIN SHIP.
VERY WELL.

KEEP YOUR EYES
DOWN. ANSWER
ONLY WHAT THEY
ASK.

WE'RE
NOTHING.

BEYOND THAT LAKE
LIES A WORLD NOT
BUILT FOR MEN
LIKE US.

BUT THAT'S
EXACTLY WHY
WE'RE HERE.

IN A REALM
OF LIGHT,
WE CARRY
OUR SHADOWS.

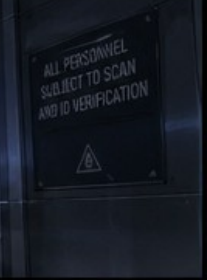
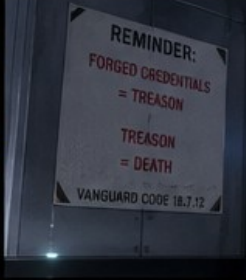
AND PRAY
THEY DON'T
SEE THEM.

VANGUARD

ORBITAL COMMAND



SECURITY GATE // PERIMETER ZETA
CLEARANCE LEVELS 3 AND ABOVE ONLY



SLOANE.
AGE: 16
VANGUARD CADET
(RANK WITHHELD)
CLEARANCE: FORGED

CADET SLOANE.

ROUTINE ACCESS.



HM.
INTERESTING.



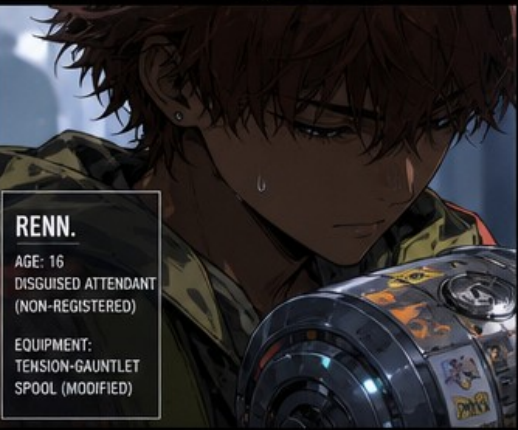
SEARCH PROTOCOL?

BYPASS

FLAG

ALERT

(TREASON PROTOCOL)



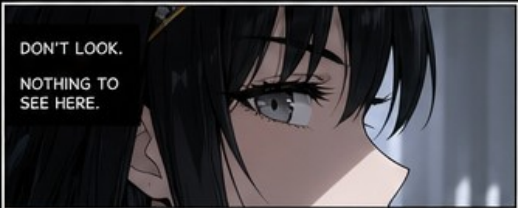
RENN.
AGE: 16
DISGUISED ATTENDANT
(NON-REGISTERED)
EQUIPMENT:
TENSION-GAUNTLET
SPOOL (MODIFIED)



'PROCEED.
THIS TIME.



WHITEPOINT VANGUARD ACADEMY
RECRUITMENT WING - LEVEL 6



DON'T LOOK.
NOTHING TO
SEE HERE.



KEEP YOUR
GRIN BURIED,
RENN.



ACT LIKE
YOU BELONG.

BREATHE.
MATCH PACE.
DON'T DRAW
ATTENTION.

EYES FRONT.
POSTURE.
PROTOCOL..



SOLID-WATER
LAKE.
BEAUTIFUL.
IMPOSSIBLE.
LETHAL..



TENSION-GAUNTLET
SPOOL.
DENTED.
STICKERED.
UNREGISTERED.
PERFECT.



VANGUARD CADET.
RANK STRIPPED.
THREAD BARELY
HOLDS.
STAY SHARP.
STAY STILL.



ONE LOOK.
ONE SLIP.
THAT'S ALL.



YOU ALWAYS
THIS LOUD IN
YOUR HEAD?

ONLY WHEN
YOU'RE THIS CLOSE.
KEEP UP.



DOCKSIDE, CARTISAN HOLD.

HIDDEN IN PLAIN CARGO.
THE WINDJAMMER
"ORPHEUS"

C'MON...
C'MON...

BIX.
FOURTEEN.
TENSION-GRID
INTERPRETER.

HOLD...
HOLD...

CODA.
ANOMALOUS SIGNAL.
ECHO-LOCATION UNIT.
PARTS UNKNOWN.

TIK.
TIK.
TIK.
TIK.

BIX...
THE GRID IS
SHUDDERING.
AGAIN.

FORTRESS KESTREL.
TENSION-GRID FEED
(UNSTABLE)

TENSION LEVEL

100%
75%
50%
25%
0%
0%

THOSE
ANCHOR POINTS
SHOULDN'T BE
PHASING—!

I KNOW,
I KNOW...

JUST NEED
THREE MORE
SAMPLES...

TIK-
TIK-TIK-TIK-TIK-

ANOTHER
BARGE...
CLOSING.

IF THEY
DECIDE TO
INSPECT—

FOCUS,
BIX.
FOCUS.

EVERY TICK
COUNTS.
EVERY LINE
HOLDS.

BELOW THE SEVENTH RING,
BEYOND THE ARCHIVAL SILENCE,
LIES THE VANGUARD'S OLDEST
CONTAINMENT VAULT.

SLOANE CAN UNLOCK IT.
IF SHE'S STILL WORTHY.



RANK STRIPPED.
CADENCE REMAINS.
SLOANE OF HOUSE CADETH.
VANGUARD CADET, DIVISION NULL.
CLEARANCE REVOKED.
TRUST... PENDING.

ONE.
DISAVOW.

TWO.
RELINQUISH.

THREE.
SURRENDER.

FOUR.
ENTREAT.

FIVE.
RECEIVE.

THREADS RESPOND.

CONTAINMENT ACKNOWLEDGED.

SPOOL ARMED.
LINE TENSION: STANDBY.

ACCESSING SERAPH PROTOCOL.

OKAY...
THIS IS REALLY
HAPPENING.

RENN
AGE: 16
ROLE: CLIMBER /
TENSION HANDLER

THREAT INDEX:
UNKNOWN.

THE PINNACLE
VAULT.

DEPTH: 1.6 KM
CLEARANCE: ORACLE

SSSHHHHHHHH

WHOA.

IT'S
REAL.

A SINGLE PEDESTAL.

A TRIPLE GYROSCOPIC RING
OF STAR-BRASS.

BLEEDING PURE-WHITE HARD-LIGHT
IN A SOFT CONTAINMENT FIELD.

IMPOSSIBLE.

TENSION-
GAUNTLET.

STILL
HOLDS.

THE WEAVER'S
THIMBLE.
I READ ABOUT IT.
BUT—

THE WEAVER'S THIMBLE.

LEGEND SAYS IT WAS FORGED
BEFORE THE FIRST LOOM.

USED TO NAVIGATE THREAD-SPACE.

TO REWEAVE
WHAT WAS TORN.

AND WE'RE THE ONLY
TWO PEOPLE STANDING
IN FRONT OF IT.

YEAH.
LEGENDS ARE
USUALLY TRUE.

THE WEAVER'S
THIMBLE
VANGUARD VAULT 7
DEPTH: 312 METERS

ALARM!
VAULT SEAL
COMPROMISED
ALARM
VAULT 7

STAR-BRASS
BANDS ROTATING
OUT OF PHASE

RED WARNING
STROBES
ACTIVE

MAG-LOCK
SCAMS
DISRUPTED

MICRO-DUST
DISPLACEMENT
SPIRANO

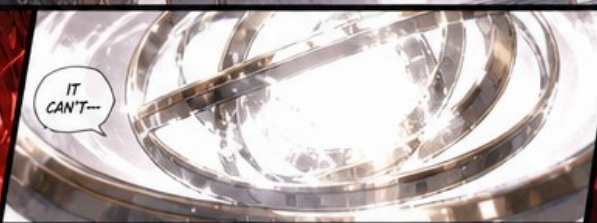


-?!-

SLOANE
AGE: 16



THAT'S
NOT---



IT
CAN'T---



TO
ARMS.



SLOANE!



COVER THE
ENTRANCE!

SILAS.

Vault Diver.
Pressure-Rated
to 7,000m.

Now entering
unpressurized
space.

SILAS

Former Vault Diver
Cut from the Manifest
for Cause.
Last known words
three years ago—
"The weight
remembers."

Renn.
Sloane.

Still breathing.
Good.
Means I still
have time.

You
didn't come
to talk.

No.
I came to
cut something
loose.

SUPPORT CABLE 4B
PRIMARY LOAD-BEARING
TENSION CRITICAL
FAILURE WILL CASCADE

SILAS: TARGET LOCKED

KZZRRINNGG—

SILAS...?!

WARNING
VAULT INTEGRITY
FAILURE IMMINENT
T-MINUS 02:17

RENN

Sixteen.
Wired for tension.
Too quick to panic.
Won't live long
enough to regret it.

CHK—

TENSION-GAUNTLET
MODEL: KESTREL-7
MANUAL OVERRIDE
SPOOL ENGAGED
CABLE LOAD:
83% AND RISING

It's been
too long,
Silas.

SLOANE

Sixteen.
Vanguard Cadet.
Stripped of rank
for reasons
that remain
unspoken.
Smiles anyway.
That's worse.

Then we'll
see what falls.

VAULT CHAMBER
SECURE. SEALED. CLASS IV.
ALARM PROTOCOL: **CRIMSON**

INTRUDER IDENTIFIED:
SLOANE.
VANGUARD CADET.
RANK STRIPPED.

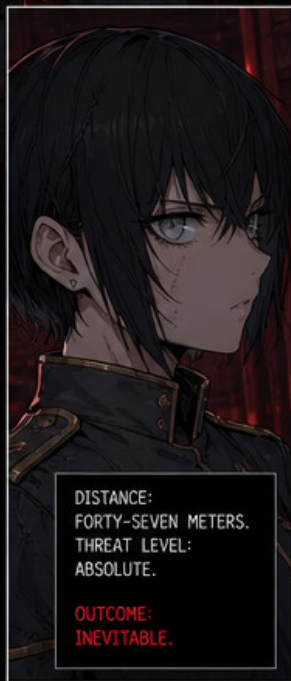
STATUS: **UNREPENTANT.**

RESPONSE:
LORD-WARDEN
VALERIUS.
VANGUARD ANCHORITE.
EXECUTIVE AUTHORITY.



SLOANE.
AGE: SIXTEEN.
GREY EYES.
NO INSIGNIA.
ALL DEBT REMAINS.

I DIDN'T
COME HERE TO
BEG.





WEAVER'S
THIMBLE.

THREE TURNS.
THREE PROMISES.
ONE WAY OUT.

RENN.

STAY
LOW.

I'VE
GOT THIS.

CADET
SLOANE.

YOU STAND
DOWN.
NOW.

LORD-WARDEN
VALERIUS
KEEPER OF THE
VANGUARD VAULT

YOU WANT HIM,
YOU TAKE ME
FIRST.

SILAS
GRAVITY DIVER
TRAITOR
LINE-CUTTER

SUCH PRETTY
THREADS.
SUCH WASTEFUL
WEIGHTS.

I DON'T
WANT TO
DIE TODAY.

NOT IF I CAN
HELP IT.

EVERY LINE
HAS ITS
BREAKING
POINT.

I JUST SPEED
IT ALONG.

KRRININCH

RANK
STRIPPED.

NAME
RETAINED.

VOW
UNCHANGED.

YOU
OVER-
ESTIMATE
YOUR
VALUE,
CADET.

SHIIING

THERE.
THAT ONE'S
LOOSE.



LORD-WARDEN
VALERIUS.

SLOANE.
VANGUARD CADET.
SIXTEEN.

RANK INSIGNIA
REVOKED.

THE TETHER
OBEYS THE
WARDEN.

DIVE!

KRAAASH!



THE VAULT WAS
NEVER MEANT TO
FALL THIS WAY.

GRAVITY IS
UNRAVELING.

AND SILAS
JUST SEVERED
THE LAST LINE
HOLDING MERCY
IN PLACE.

SILAS

『MERCY IS A
SUPPORT CABLE.』

『I CUT WHAT
SHOULD NEVER
BE RELIED ON.』

THE AIR
DOESN'T JUST
BREAK—

IT TEARS.

HIS HANDS
WON'T STOP
SHAKING.

HE'S ALREADY
FALLING.

RENN

『I'VE GOT
A LINE!』

IF THERE'S
GROUND—

I'LL MAKE
MY OWN.

SLOANE

『HOLD THE
ANGLE!』

THE WHOLE
CHAMBER IS
TILTING—

DISCIPLINE WON'T
OUTWEIGH THIS.

THERE IS NO
UP ANYMORE.

ONLY
APART.

SILAS

『GRAVITY IS
A PRIVILEGE.』

『TODAY, I
WITHDRAW IT.』

VANGUARD CADET
SLOANE

AGE: 16

TWO OATHS.
TWO BREAKS.
ONE LINE
WE HOLD.

HA.
LOOK AT YOU.
FUTILE LITTLE
LINES.
I'LL CUT THE
AIRZ ITSELF.

VANGUARD LORD-WARDEN
VALERIUS

AGE: 40+

UNDERTOW ENGINEER
SILAS

AGE: 30

TENSION WEAVER
RENN

AGE: 16

YES, MY
LORD-WARDEN.
I UNDERSTAND
PERFECTLY.

SLOANE
VANGUARD CADET.
OATHSOUND.
RANK REMOVED.
NOT HER LIMIT.

SILAS
UNDERTOW ENGINEER.
GRAVITY DIVER.
REALITY SHEARER.
HOLDING ON.
BARELY.

JUST NEED
A BREATH—
ONE GOOD
BREATH—

ON IT!
THREADS
OUT!

RENN
TENSION WEAVER.
THREADS THE IMPOSSIBLE.
SCARED. STILL SMILING.
THAT'S THE POINT.

**LORD-WARDEN
VALERIUS**
EXECUTOR OF THE
VANGUARD PRINCIPLES.
AUTHORITY
MADE FLESH.

CADET.
DISCIPLINE
IS SURVIVAL.
PROVE YOU
UNDERSTAND.

RUPTURE.
REND.
REWRITE.
THAT'S ALL
IT TAKES.

THUMP!

KNOT!

TCHK!

WE DON'T WIN.
WE HOLD.
TOGETHER.
THAT'S
ENOUGH.



RENN.
SIXTEEN.
NOT THE
CHOSEN.
NOT THE
STRONGEST.

JUST
THE ONLY
ONE STUPID
ENOUGH TO
PUNCH BACK.

WEAVER'S
THIMBLE.

THREE BANDS
OF STAR-BRASS.
THREE PROMISES.
ONE IMPOSSIBLE
THREAD.

WHIRRRR

TENSION-
GAUNTLET
SPOOL.

DENTED.
SCRATCHED.
MINE.

SNAPS TIGHT
LIKE A HEARTBEAT
UNDER A FALLING
SKY.

CH-THUNK

I DIDN'T
MEAN TO.
I JUST—

BUT THE
WEFT
DOESN'T
ASK.
IT ANSWERS.

SHIING

A BLINDING
THREAD.
BORN WHITE.
HARD AS
TRUTH.

CUTS LIES.
CUTS STONE.
CUTS THE END
IN HALF.

KREAATTTT

IT HURTS.
SO MUCH.
BUT IT
HOLDS.

LIKE I
DECIDED
THE SKY
WOULD
WAIT.

NOT A HERO.
NOT YET.

JUST...
THREAD.

AND
STUBBORN.

KRAA
KRAA
KRAA

VAULT OF CHORIS-7
23:41 LOCAL

RENN SET THE TENSION.

SLOANE HELD THE ANGLE.

GRAVITY DID THE REST.

THREE...

CHNK!

RENN!

I
KNOW!

...TWO...

...ONE.

FOCUS.
NOT VICTORY.
EXTRACTION.

SHE DOESN'T
CELEBRATE.
SHE CALCULATES.

SOMEONE WILL
CALL IT HEROIC.
SHE'LL CALL IT
INEFFICIENT.

LORD-WARDEN VALERIUS
SEES THE SAME SKY.

HE JUST COUNTS
DIFFERENT OUTCOMES.

THE VAULT IS
COMPROMISED.
THE EQUATION
REMAINS.

THIS WAS NEVER
THE ENDGAME.
IT WAS THE
TRIGGER.

TO BE CONTINUED...